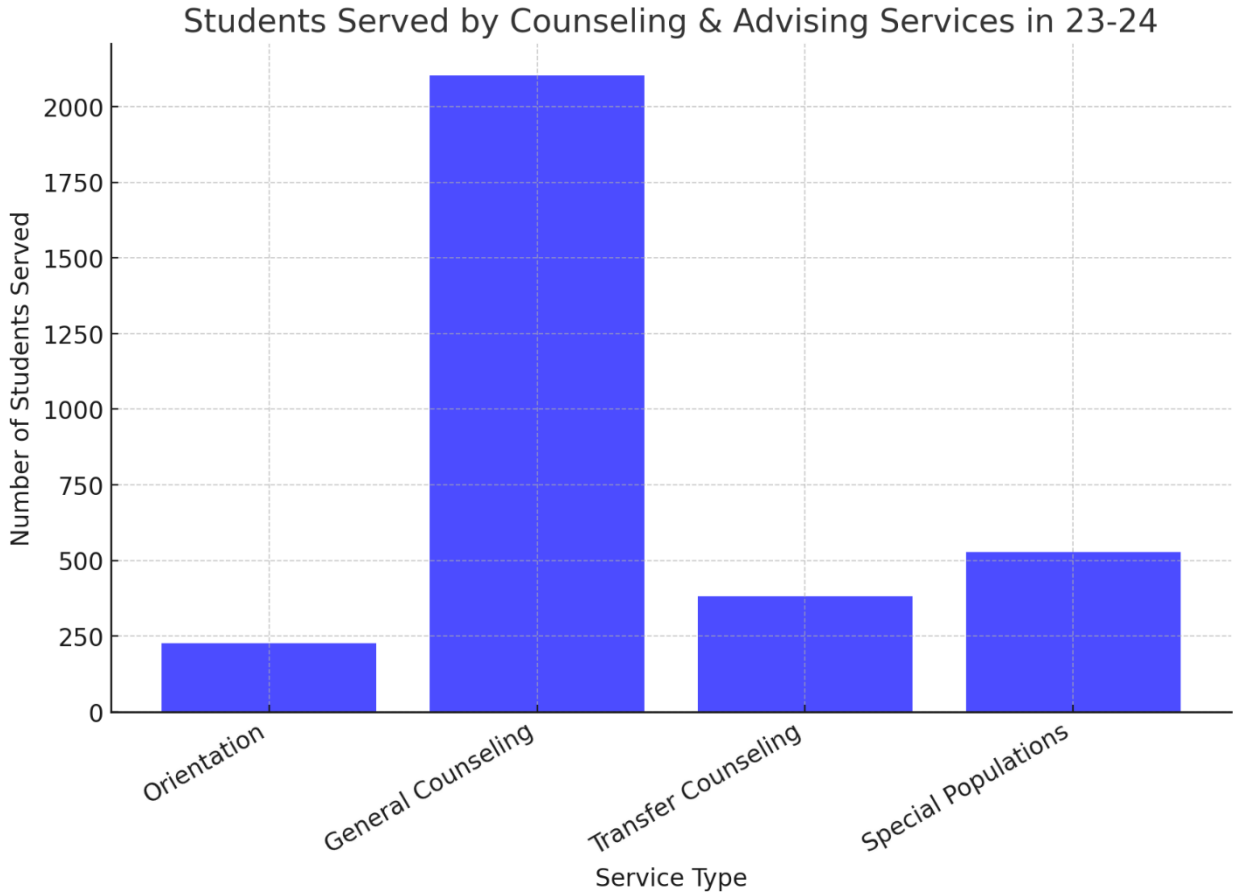
1. Program Description

- **Mission**: The mission of the Counseling & Advising Department is to support students in achieving their academic, career, and personal goals. The department offers services that help students navigate their academic pathways, meet transfer requirements, or align with personal career aspirations.
- **Alignment with College Mission**: The department advances the college's mission by empowering students through personalized counseling, facilitating transfer opportunities, and supporting students in achieving degrees or certifications.
- **Organizational Structure and Staffing**: The department is composed of academic counselors, academic advisors, and support staff. The Vice President of Student Services is the administrator over the department.
- **Who You Serve**: The department serves a diverse range of students, including those seeking orientation, career guidance, transfer exploration, financial aid information, and students from special populations such as, but not limited to, Veterans, International, CalWORKs, and EOPS/CARE. A significant number of students (857 in 2023) required general counseling, and another 764 in the same year sought transfer-related advising, indicating the high demand for support.

2. Services Provided (with Trend Data for 23-24):



- **Orientation:** Orientation includes pre-SOAR (Siskiyous Orientation, Advising and Registration) and SOAR sessions and provides assistance with the application process for registration, financial aid, special populations, scholarships, and Siskiyou Promise. In addition, department personnel review college policies and procedures, provide campus tours, education planning, external transcript review, and referrals to other campus support services. For all types of orientation services provided, 227 students were served.
- **General Counseling**: 2,103 appointments for general counseling were completed. This averages to be approximately 350 appointments per counselor or advisor. General counseling includes career, personal, education planning, course scheduling, petitions to graduation, over unit requests, prerequisites, course overlap request, and more.
- **Transfer Counseling**: Transfer counseling appointments peaked at 381 in the most recent academic year, reflecting ongoing efforts to guide students through their transfer process. Transfer counseling includes assistance with university applications, understanding transfer requirements, articulation agreements, transfer workshops, GPA calculation, transferability of coursework, and more.
- **Special Populations**: Counseling appointments for special populations, such as Veterans, CalWORKs, NextUP, EOPS, and CARE, have consistently shown a demand for personalized support across multiple years. In the most recent year, 528 counseling appointments occurred with students from special populations. Counseling and advising with special population students includes all other services provided by the department but also includes many other services that are provided specifically for students from special population groups.
- **Academic Standing Support**: Dismissals have fluctuated across the years, with a spike in 2021-2022 and a slight reduction in 2023-2024 indicating the ongoing need to address academic performance through advising interventions. In the 23-24 academic the board policies and academic procedures related to academic and progress probation and dismissal were overhauled to provide a better framework to support students who are subject to probation or dismissal.

3. External Factors with Significant Impact

- **Budgetary Constraints**: The department has been impacted by limited financial resources, particularly by limited funding provided from the General Fund. Counseling & Advising is almost entirely funded from categorical budgets.
- **Requirements of Four-Year Institutions**: The department ensures compliance with transfer requirements set by four-year institutions, which impacts the counseling services needed for articulation and transfer.
- **Legislative and Chancellor's Office Mandates**: Federal, State, and Chancellor's Office mandates require constant changes to processes, procedures, and services for students. Frequently these mandates come unfunded or with little assistance with providing the staffing, technology, or expertise needed to implement the changes.
- **Geographical and Resource Limitations**: The District serves one of the largest geographic regions in the State. Population centers are small and spread out across the service area. Services such as mental health, housing, childcare, transportation, domestic

violence support, employment opportunities, and technology are limited. The District service area is also impacted by inclement weather, frequent wildfires, and inconsistent power and broadband issues.

4. Service Area Outcomes (SAOs/SLOs)

- Students who receive counseling services will demonstrate the ability to access and understand their degree audit and education plan, enabling them to effectively monitor academic progress and make informed decisions about their educational journey.
- Students who participate in SOAR or receive counseling services will be more likely to enroll in math and English in their first year of attendance.

5. Quantitative & Qualitative Data

- There was a total enrollment of 2,808 credit students during academic year 23-24. College of the Siskiyous current counseling and advising staff consists of 5 full-time counselors and advisors. The breakdown is 3 full-time counselors and 2 full-time academic advisors. Not all counselors are assigned as full-time as some are assigned a portion of their load to Articulation or Transfer Center.

  This staffing equates to a staggering ratio of 1 counselor or advisor for every 562 credit students. At this scale, it is impossible to provide the mandatory counseling and advising that each student would need to thrive academically and personally.

  Mandatory counseling and advising have consistently proven to enhance student retention, academic success, and overall satisfaction. Traditional counseling appointments are scheduled for one hour. Advisor appointments vary. Counselors and advisors have different roles and there are only certain appointments that are seen by counselors such as comprehensive education plans, academic dismissal appointments, petitions to repeat, and over 18 units.

  With current staffing, even if each counselor or advisor saw 7-8 students per day, they could only reach a fraction of the student population within a semester. To realistically support the needs of our entire student body, we need to expand our team to meet the demands of mandatory counseling and advising, ensuring that every student receives the guidance they need to stay on course and succeed.

6. Evaluation of Program Effectiveness

- **Student Demographics**: The department's services closely align with the college's diverse student population, ensuring equitable access to counseling resources.
- **Operational Efficiency**: The use of existing resources, such as staff and budget allocation, is well managed. However, additional resources are necessary to address the increasing demand for services, particularly related to improving the use of technology to serve students and be more efficient.

- **Staffing & Development**: The current staffing levels are sufficient but stretched. Professional development opportunities are essential to ensure counselors stay updated on articulation agreements and transfer requirements.

7. Progress on Prior Goals

- **Increase Educational Plan Attainment at COS for all Students:** To attain this the Counseling & Advising Department identified the three indicators of success below.

    1. Turn on forward facing degree audit portion for student by October 1, 2022- Completed.
    2. By July 1, 2022, identify structurally who and where the scribe will be for DegreeWorks- Completed in fall 2024.
    3. Create District funded adjunct faculty budget to help cover peak registration times and off-contract time for counselors- Created fall 2022 but the budget is no longer sufficient to meet the needs of the department.

8. Vision for the Future

- **Vision**: Over the next four years, the Counseling & Advising Department aims to expand its outreach efforts by collaborating with other COS departments, implement ConexED, and further align the Student-Centered Funding Formula metrics. This includes increasing early intervention for at-risk students to prevent academic dismissals. Support the elimination of barriers to student access and success across College of the Siskiyous.
- **Alignment with College Vision**: The department's future plans align with the college's vision of education and engagement by empowering students to succeed academically and in their future careers.

9. Four-Year Action Plan

- **Goals**:
    - Expand early intervention programs to reduce academic dismissals.
    - Increase communication and collaboration with Student Services Departments and the Academic Affairs Office.
    - Increase transfer services within the Counseling & Advising Department.
    - Strengthen partnerships with local K-12 schools to align with Vision 2030 goals.
- **Resources Needed**:
    - Additional staffing for counseling services to meet rising student demand.
        - A full time Office Assistant
    - Increase part-time general counseling budget by $25,000 annually
    - Signage for the building

10. Conclusion

The Counseling & Advising Department has demonstrated resilience and adaptability, effectively responding to rising demand for services and the needs of a diverse student body. Key

areas of strength include general counseling and transfer support, while areas for future growth focus on improving early interventions and addressing academic dismissals.

This review provides a comprehensive overview, including both quantitative data (e.g., counseling appointments, academic dismissals) and qualitative insights (e.g., partnerships, student engagement), ensuring a holistic understanding of the department's impact and areas for growth.